Spirit was renewed.

Our minds were turning towards the 2016 World Twenty20 tournament, to be hosted by India, and we dared to believe we could move beyond recent disappointments, find some form at the right moment and, at last, win an official ICC limited-overs tournament. We may have lacked depth and experience in the longer format, but, at the very least, we had a puncher's chance in T20 cricket.

The Australians made a detour on their way to the tournament and arrived in South Africa to play three warm-up T20 internationals; we won in Durban, but then lost in Cape Town and Johannesburg. Even so, our starting XI looked strong enough, combining talent with T20 experience, and lined up as: Amla, De Kock, De Villiers, Du Plessis (captain), Duminy, Miller, Morris, Abbott, Steyn, Rabada and Tahir.

We travelled to India and prepared to compete with England, West Indies, Sri Lanka and Afghanistan in Group 1, with the top two teams in the pool advancing to the semifinals.

Our opening match, against England in Mumbai, was going according to plan when we batted first and scored 229 for four in our 20 overs. We should then have closed out the win, but England got off to a flier. Our fielding was average at times and Joe Root led his team to a notable win with two balls to spare.

Playing with no margin for error, we faced an improving Afghanistan at the same venue, scored 209 in 20 overs and withstood an early onslaught from Mohammad Shahzad, the Afghan captain. Imran was again our most economical bowler, and Chris Morris took four wickets, as we won by 37 runs. Back on track, still fighting, we needed to win our third group match against the West Indies in Nagpur.

The pitch was low and slow, and 150 would have been par. Sent in to bat first, we needed to be calm and smart. Instead, there was a run out off the third ball, everything became a little frantic and, in the blink of an eye, we found ourselves in serious trouble at 47 for five. Quinton,